

Military Crackdown on 25 March and aftermath

Operation Searchlight and Mujibnagar Government: Beginning of Muktiyuddho

Before military crackdown

- The non-cooperation movement that started with the postponement of National Assembly Session on March 1 continued non stop until 25 March.
- On 2 March 1971, this initial version of the Bangladesh flag was hoisted in Bangladesh for the first time at Dhaka University, by student leader A. S. M. Abdur Rab, the then Vice President of Dhaka University Central Students' Union (DUCSU). The flag was conceived so as to exclude the star and crescent considered as symbols of West Pakistan (now Pakistan).
- During this entire period, the writ of the central govt did not run in East Pakistan and Sheikh Mujib Became the de-facto govt. All organs of the govt reported to Sheikh Mujib's headquarters at 32 Dhanmondi for instructions and guidance.
- Yahya Khan and Sheikh Mujib met several times and the bulk of negotiations was carried out between Yahya Khan and Sheikh Mujib's team. Bhutto also visited Dhaka during this time. Though negotiations were not terminated, Yahya Khan left Dhaka on the night of 25 March giving instruction for a military crackdown code named 'Operation Searchlight' on unarmed Bengalis.

Flag of Bangladesh used during the Liberation War



Operation Searchlight

- Operation Searchlight, a blue print of genocide was put into operation on the night between 25 and 26 March 1971. Ordered by the central government in West Pakistan, the original plans envisioned taking control of all of East Pakistan's major cities on 26 March, and then eliminating all Bengali opposition, whether political or military within the following month.
- Lt General Niazi gave a graphic account of the ferocity of onslaught on the people of Bangladesh: “On the night between 25/26 March 1971, General Tikka struck. The peaceful night was turned into wailing, crying and burning. General Tikka let loose everything at his disposal as if raiding an enemy not dealing with his misguided and misled people. The military action was a display of stark cruelty, more merciless than the massacre of Bukhara and Bagdad by Genghis and Hulagu Khan or at Jalianwalabagh by the British General Dyer. His order to his troops were “I want the land and not the people”.
- Bengali intelligentsia, academics and Hindus were widely targeted alongside Bengali nationalists—with widespread, indiscriminate extrajudicial killings. The operation also directly precipitated the 1971 Bangladesh genocide, in which between 300,000 and 3,000,000 Bengalis were killed while around 10 million fled to neighbouring India as refugees.



4. There was a record of the frequency of use of the following services:
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10,000 DEAD IN PAKISTAN BATTLES

Busy day for Premier in Edinburgh

Major crisis looms along DMZ

Reuter said fighting was said to be heavy in Sanghar where West Pakistan troops are reported to have

Declaration of Independence

- Sheikh Mujib was arrested by the Pakistan military immediately after the brutal crackdown on the unarmed people of Bangladesh. On receiving the news of the brutal military crackdown, Bangabandhu before his arrest at the early hours of 26 March sent the following declaration of independence through wireless transmission to whole of Bangladesh:
- “This may be my last message, from today Bangladesh is independent. I call upon the people of Bangladesh wherever you might be and with whatever you have to resist the army of occupation to the last. Your fight must go on until the last soldier of the Pakistan occupation army is expelled from the soil of Bangladesh and final victory is achieved”
- Bangabandhu's declaration was transmitted from Chittagong Radio on 26 March by Awami League leaders and concerned officials of the radio station.
- On 27 March, the then Major of East Bengal Regiment Major Ziaur Rahman declared independence on behalf of “our great leader Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman” from Kalurghat Radio station in Chittagong.
- The broadcast by Ziaur Rahman’s declaration helped galvanize support for Liberation War of Bangladesh.

Formation of Provisional Govt in exile (Mujibnagar Govt)

- The Provisional Government of Bangladesh, also known as the [Mujibnagar Government](#), was Bangladesh's first government-in-exile, formed on April 10, 1971, to lead the Bangladesh Liberation War. Headed by Prime Minister [Tajuddin Ahmad](#) and with [Sheikh Mujibur Rahman](#) as President, this government-in-exile operated from Kolkata, India. It provided supreme leadership for the liberation movement, establishing a cabinet, armed forces, and a diplomatic corps, and issued the [Proclamation of Independence](#) which served as Bangladesh's interim constitution.
- The capture of Sheikh Mujib during Operation Searchlight might have been a big blow for the resistance had Tajuddin Ahmad failed to rally support for his leadership from the other Awami League senior members and create the Bangladesh government in exile.
- The Mujibnagar government coordinated the war efforts of the Mukti Bahini and the nascent Bangladesh Armed Forces. It had its own postal service. Its public relations strategy featured a widely popular radio station known as Swadhin Bangla Betar Kendra.
- It coordinated with the Government of India in conducting the armed resistance against the Pakistan army and also addressing the refugee crisis.
- It also undertook an international campaign to garner support for Bangladesh's independence, calling for stopping the genocide and preventing a refugee crisis. It appointed special envoys and operated representative missions in New Delhi, Washington, D.C., and London among many other cities.

Oath-taking ceremony

- The oath taking ceremony took place on 17 April, at a village along the India-Bangladesh border, called Baidyanathtala, in Kushtia district (currently Meherpur district), on Bangladeshi soil.
- The ceremony was conducted by Abdul Mannan. Professor Muhammad Yusuf Ali read the proclamation of independence, drafted by Amir-ul Islam, an Awami League MNA-elect and barrister of the Dacca High Court, with the help of Subrata Roy Chowdhury, a barrister of the Calcutta High Court, retroactively in effect from 10 April.
- Answering a journalist during the ceremony, Tajuddin named the place Mujibnagar, after Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. Later the government-in-exile came to be popularly known as the Mujibnagar Government.
- Mujibnagar was abandoned quickly after the oath ceremony as participants feared a raid by Pakistani forces. The government settled in Kolkata, in exile, for the rest of the war—briefly at a house on Ballyganj Circular Road and then at 8 Theatre Road.